Bad Case (Of Loving You)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38337976.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
gangs all here - Freeform, bunch of idiots don’t understand viral illness, netossa is so Done, Sickfic, kissing the homies goodnight, dudes being guys, everyone is stupid and that’s why they’re great, amputee scorpia

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Part 3 of No Game, No Gain

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Bad Case (Of Loving You)

by PointlesslyPoetic

Summary

A fun night out ends up having a larger impact than just furthering Adora's crush, or expanding Double Trouble's drink menu.

(Alternately: The Gang Gives Each Other Mono)

Notes

This was born of several stupid conversations about mono, kissing the homies goodnight, sugar daddy hordak, Double Trouble's speak easy, and the inherent polyamory of the Alliance.

See the end of the work for more notes

Like all avalanches, it started with one innocuous little snowball. Adora and Catra had been hanging out at Double Trouble's bar- no, lounge, as they preferred- relaxing, chatting, and, maybe, flirting a little bit. Just a bit. They had most certainly not been on a date, Adora affirmed several times to Bow and Glimmer before she left the apartment. Catra had not once ever called it a date, or even alluded to the idea that it might be one. She had walked up to Adora on Wednesday after their shared HIIT block, and said, and she quoted, "Hey Doofus, I'm sure you're not busy on Friday night, so let's go out. DT's spot? I'll buy you a drink."

And, per usual, Catra had been right; Adora wasn't busy that Friday. She was almost never busy on Friday, but usually that was by default as Friday happened to be the night all their other friends coupled or doubled up and went out alone. Bow and Glimmer's one year anniversary was the following week, when they'd all be in Utah for Nationals, so they were going out to a very exclusive, romantic restaurant on their own. Scorpia and Perfuma were leaving that night for a Holistic Couples' Retreat near Portland, so they were out. Mermista had some wedding in New York City, and had apparently "needed a date or whatever", so she and Sea Hawk were catching a red eye right after Friday practice. Spinnerella and Netossa were very cool, but Fridays was their fifteen-year standing date night, and Adora hated the feeling of intruding. Entrapta could only be handled in small doses, and the end of a long week was not the ideal situation for optimal social interaction, according to, well, both of them. Frosta was too little for anything remotely enjoyable except gaming, and Adora's laptop was still being repaired. So, yes, Catra was right. Adora had nothing planned except maybe Mexican takeout and a few episodes of Xena or Buffy.

"Yeah! Sounds great. You'll pick me up?"

Catra had smirked. "Something like that."

So, despite Bow and Glimmer's assurances that this was, in fact, a date, Adora was excited to spend a night alone with her best

friend. She only hoped the butterflies in her stomach were just leftover adrenaline from her time on the mat, and not some sort of bug. She would hate to get Catra sick.

Adora threw on the outfit Glimmer had laid out for her before she and Bow left- apparently, her favorite BassPro Shop tee and torn mom jeans were 'inappropriate' for the lounge, and if DT saw her in that, they would, probably, 'rip her apart with their teeth'. Glimmer may have had a point about that last bit. But still! Adora could dress herself. However, the ensemble Glimmer had picked was actually very nice, so she put it on, albeit with many theatrical grumbles.

It was pretty satisfying to see Catra's eyebrows shoot up when she left the lobby of their building. Glimmer had picked out a casual yet flirty red dress- solid on the boatnecked top, geometric patterns on the gauzy, flowing bottom- with plain gold jewelry, studs and choker. Adora had thrown her worn leather jacket over it, leaving it open. And Bow must have picked the shoes, because they were far more obnoxious than her usual boots- open toed pumps with a teeny bit of lift, black and gold. Adora had swiped on a bit of mascara and braided her hair to the side, a much more casual look than her severe ponytail.

So, yeah, she looked pretty damn good. Catra, in distressed black jeans, embroidered Docs, and a burgundy cropped tank under her own leather jacket, whistled low. "Damn, Grayskull, you don't clean up half-bad."

"Thanks," Adora snorted. "You, too. Where's your car?"

Catra smirked again. "Behind me."

"That's a motorcycle."

"Very astute."

"You…I've never been on a motorcycle."

"You'll love it. Probably. Or you won't and you can uber home. Not really my problem. Here," she tossed Adora a helmet. "Slap that bad boy on."

She yanked the helmet on and fastened the strap as tight as she could, trying to maintain any semblance of cool. Catra helped her to straddle the rear seat, and then climbed in front. Adora wrapped her arms around Catra's middle, tight. She had little interest in falling off a bike and missing nationals or, stars forbid, the Olympics. Luckily, DT's club was barely a five minute ride away, and it wasn't long before Catra was helping her off the bike.

"So?"

Adora flushed and averted her eyes. "It was kind of fun, I guess."

Catra snorted, squeaky and jagged. Adora thought she had the cutest laugh, but she knew Catra would appreciate her saying so as much as a flat tire. "That's the spirit. C'mon, I'm too sober for a Friday night."

They passed the fine French restaurant that took up the top half of the establishment, making their way down a set of stairs in a small, covered alley below street level. Catra knocked on the metallic green door twice exactly, waiting a beat, and then knocked twice again. A viewport slid open at eye level, and a fuschia gaze met theirs. "Password."

"Ottoman."

The port slid closed, and the door swung open. A wall of sensations assaulted Adora as it did; the thick, cloying scent of hairspray, expensive booze, and poorly-hidden cigarettes and weed, a loud, thumping and familiar bass, flashing lights, glasses clinking, heels stomping. Catra grabbed her hand and tugged her in, nodding to the doorman. She led Adora to a small booth, cordoned off by a velvet rope, just to the right of the large, glittering stage. Adora balked. "Catra, we can't just sit here, it's reserved."

“Yeah, dummy,” Catra rolled her eyes, but it was fond. “For me.”

“What?”

“Darling~!” A melodious, trilling voice startled Adora bad enough that she jumped, whirling to face the speaker. Double Trouble stood just behind her in full regalia, a wide and predatory grin stretching their face. Adora was not easily unnerved, or intimidated, but Catra’s friend gave her very strange “vibes”, as Perfuma would put it. They were tall, roughly six foot five, and wiry. Adora had never seen them without their yellow, reptilian contact lenses in. Their hair was a natural blonde, more platinum than Adora’s, shaved on either side and pinned back. Tonight, they wore an ensemble of an emerald green and black suit that flared into a high-low ballgown past the waist. Thigh high, bedazzled cowboy boots gave them an extra two inches. The post unnerving aspect of DT’s overall appearance was by and large their teeth, though. Catra said they were custom made veneers; the cuspids and bicupsids, top and bottom, were filed into sharp points, lending to the overall ‘predator’ feels. Adora swallowed and smiled, hoping it wasn’t shaky.

“Hey, DT!”

“What’s up, Trouble?”

DT leaned in to hug and kiss Catra near the air of both cheeks. “It’s wonderful to see you both. Adora, it’s been so long, I was wondering when you were going to grace my humble little establishment with your presence.”

“Aw, geez,” Adora’s hand flew to the back of her neck. “I’ve just been so busy with training, you know how it is.”

DT pouted theatrically. “Well, I certainly hope you haven’t been too busy for our little Kitten here.”

“Huh-?”

“So, Trouble, what are you mixing tonight?” Catra cut in smoothly. She seemed tense, suddenly, and her narrowed eyes put Adora on edge. “Anything special for me?”

“Darling, everything I do for you is special,” they rolled their eyes. “Take a seat, take a load off, I’ll have Griz bring your drinks by in a minute.” Before Adora could open her mouth and say, ‘excuse me but I literally haven’t ordered a damn thing yet’, they were sashaying away, glinting and flashing under the strobing fuschia lights.
Catra tugged Adora down to the booth. “Relax, Princess. We’re here to have a good time, right? Just sit back and let yourself unwind, enjoy the unknown, embrace the unexpected, whatever.”

And Adora did. Or at least, she tried very hard, which was maybe a bit oxymoronic, but it worked for her, alright? She let Catra feed her greasy nachos, spiced wings covered in a strange assortment of cheeses, fattening and delicious foods her personal trainer was certainly going to kill her for, but as Catra laughed- really laughed- and scooched closer and closer, Adora couldn’t bring herself to care. The cheeseburger quesadilla paired disturbingly well with whatever pink, glittering concoction she was nursing, and it wasn’t long before she was getting another- and another.

At some point, the stage lights started streaking, and the bodies on the stage and dancefloor were blurring, and she was feeling lighter than air, laughing over some ridiculous video with Catra in their own little world.

“Hey, should we do a Tiktok together?” Adora slurred. “Like, while we’re here?”

“Nah, but we should definitely grab a snapchat.”

Catra flicked open the app, and pressed back into Adora, turning the phone this way and that to try and get them both in frame. “Here, I have an idea.” Adora murmured into Catra’s ear; the music was throbbing now, turning her brain to goo, and it was the only way to be heard over the pop-funk remix of ‘What’s Love Got

to Do with It?'. She pulled Catra up into her lap, arranging them so Adora's arms were around her waist, her chin hooked over the gymnast's shoulder. "Good?"

Catra's tongue darted out to lick her lips, and Adora drunkenly traced the motion with her eyes. "Yeah. Say cheese, Princess."

Catra snapped a decidedly very cute picture of them, and Adora made her save it and DM it to her, so she wouldn't accidentally lose it if she forgot to take a screenshot. They took a few silly videos, the pair of them lip syncing to whatever was blasting in the club and firing it off to their friends. Replies trickled in, and Adora was secretly grateful she had an excuse to justify keeping her best friend on her lap a bit longer. Not that she really wanted to dive into that thought at the moment.

They aww'd (and made barf noises) at Glimmer and Bow's artful pic of their joined hands under candlelight on a white tablecloth laden with rose petals. Catra laughed very hard at Scorpia's snapchat of Perfuma 'communing' with a large spider in their cabin. Communing, in this moment, meant screaming very loudly, and asking the intruder to leave, very politely all things considered. Mermista's first replying snap was Sea Hawk asleep in an uber with a pink satin mask over his eyes, obnoxiously large headphones listing off his head. The follow up picture came twenty minutes later- a breathtaking view of Times' Square from a lavish hotel dozens of floors above. Catra whined, briefly lamenting her dismissal of Mermista's invite as a joke.

"She probably was joking," Adora giggled. "Why would she take anyone but Sea Hawk?"

"Oh please, it's not like they're dating. Well, not, like, stable-ly. I could be in New York eating caviar, Adora!" Catra slumped against her, pouting. At some point, she'd slouched enough the her head was now half-tucked under Adora's chin.

Adora giggled. "I can buy you caviar from Whole Foods if it's that important."

“You have Whole Foods money?”

“No, but Glimmer does, and if I bother her enough, she’ll probably give in.”

“Adora~!,” Catra purred, drawing up to look in her eyes. “That’s downright devious for you, little miss goody-two-shoes.”

“I can be devious!” Adora huffed. “Sometimes.”

“Sure you can, Princess.”

When had they gotten so close? Adora’s eyes flicked down to Catra’s lips, so close she could feel the gymnast’s breath puffing over her lips. She shifted minutely, and watched Catra’s heterochromatic eyes widen. This close, she could see every fleck of gold in the blue, and every bit of green in the hazel. “You have beautiful eyes.” Adora said, simply, as it was a very simple fact.

Catra flushed. And then, she leaned in and-

“Kitten! I need you to try this- oh.”

They flew apart as if burned, but Adora kept a firm enough grip on Catra that she didn’t go very far. She fought off a scowl; their entire night had been free of charge so far, and she wasn’t about to snap at the person who was making that possible. Catra, however, felt no such way.

“Trouble! Do you mind?”

“Clearly you don’t,” they purred, chin perched on a manicured hand, almost clawed with acrylics. “Here, try this before you start lip locking again.”

Adora’s face was burning, but they took no notice. They slid a sparkling green drink across the table, topped with a blue whipped cream and more glitter. It looked half drank already. Catra took a long sip, gently smacking her lips and licking them and wow when did it get so hot in here?

“If you’re going for saccharine, you need more rum. If you want it lighter, or fruitier, more lime vodka. Also, this is disgusting.”

“Says you.” DT picked up the drink, took another sip, and grimaced. “Yeah, no, it’s kind of not really…doing it. Hang on.”

They vanished, but reappeared a second later, and handed back the glass. Catra took another sip, and nodded. “Slightly better than drain cleaner. I approve. Here, Princess.”

Adora took a careful sip, and then tried very hard not to gag. “Oh, wow. Is that rosemary? And vanilla?”

“Uh huh!”

“It really…hits.”

“Thank you, darling.” DT seemed genuinely pleased by that, so Adora pat herself on the back. Catra took another sip, and handed the drink back to DT. “You’ve got the Joint Lesbian Seal of Approval.”

“Perfect,” DT grinned. “I’ll call it Kitten Piss.”

“Goodbye, Trouble.”

They sauntered away cackling, and Catra turned back to Adora, almost shyly. Adora smiled. “Hey.”

“Hey Adora.”

The moment was broken, they could both feel it, so she just jostled Catra. “Wanna go get some caviar?”

Catra laughed, and Adora was glad nothing was different. Glad, and sad, all at once. What a weird feeling. She should ask Bow about it later; he was good with feelings. “Sure, Adora. I’ll call an Uber.”

“What about your bike?”

“Eh, I’ll get it in the morning,” Catra waved her off. “C’mon, Princess.”

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Glimmer groaned when she woke up on Sunday morning. Not a weird occurrence even slightly; she hated mornings, found them evil, and wished the world would shift to a universal two pm wake up time. What was weird was the fact that when she rolled over to starfish in bed like she did every morning, she slapped and kicked Bow with her sleepy limbs. He grunted, and she yelped.

“Sorry! Are you okay?”

“Huzzat?” Bow’s head popped off the pillow. “What time is it? What? Sorry for what?”

“Uhhh, like, ten? And sorry for slapping you?”

“Oh I didn’t notice.” Bow waved her off, face planting back into the pillow. He wrapped an arm around her waist, tugging her body into his, and Glimmer sighed at how wonderful his warm skin felt against hers. The PNW was consistently wet and rainy, but it had been particularly dreary lately, and she was feeling chilly morning, noon, and night. Bow was a furnace, and she wrapped herself up in him any chance she could get. Plus, he had really nice abs.

Although, this morning, she was chillier than normal, and found herself fighting away shivers, even curled up in her boyfriend’s almost-feverish heat. “I’m freezing.” She whined.

Bow cracked an eye open to look at her incredulously. “Are you alright? I’m boiling hot.”

“How?” Glimmer stared at him. “It’s like, 68 in this apartment at best. You and Adora keep it arctic.”

“We do not…usually.” Bow conceded. “C’mon. I’m sure some tea will help.”

After much moaning, groaning, distracted kisses and wandering hands, they cobbled together sleep shirts and sweatpants and padded out into the kitchen. Glimmer snagged a pair of Bow's thick wool camping socks on the way out. Adora was still asleep, it seemed, which also set off an alarm bell in Glimmer's head. Of the so-called Best Friends Squad, she herself slept the latest and hardest. Bow was a morning person, and Adora had crippling anxiety so she was always up, puttering or exercising, by the time Glimmer left her cave.

Today, the apartment was silent, save for Bow clattering around in the kitchen making breakfast. Glimmer trailed him, hoisting herself up to perch on the island. Bow had laid out the ingredients for protein french toast, eggwhite omelettes, and smoothies- their usual Sunday fair- and she alternated her attention between handing him ingredients as he needed, scrolling Tiktok and Instagram, and stealing kisses as he worked.

Glimmer loved Sundays.

"What's on the agenda for today?"

She craned her neck to check the apartment's massive whiteboard calendar. "Nothing til 5. Then we're supposed to get dinner at that bar with everyone."

Bow gasped. He must have forgotten. "Oh! With the jukebox music?"

"Yeah!" Glimmer munched on a spinach leaf while she checked her training schedule for Monday. "Do you think we could get Mermsita and Catra to line dance?"

"Like with country music? No shot."

"Nah, I totally think we could."

Bow turned to give her a skeptical smile, and she hugged him around the waist using her toned legs. He chuckled and let himself be roped into her arms. "What's your wager?"

“Hmmmmm, a massage?” She asked as innocently as she could. Bow had magic hands.

He leaned in, his lips a scant inch from her own. “I’ll take that bet.”

Even after a year together, Glimmer never got tired of kissing Bow. He smelled like sandalwood and birch, and right now he also smelled like their comforter, and breakfast in their kitchen. He smelled like home. She tilted her head to deepen the kiss, and he groaned softly into her mouth.

“Ugh, guys, really?”

Adora’s voice echoed through the kitchen, and they pulled apart. Not guiltily, or fast, because they had nothing to hide and even though she was annoyed, this was still just Adora. She had been their number one champion when they decided to take the plunge into dating, and had never been anything but supportive. Now, though, there was no tease in her voice, only genuine annoyance.

“You okay, Adora?” Bow pecked her cheek and turned back to the stove, giving the omelet a shake.

Glimmer swiveled to look at her friend and barely smothered a gasp. “Adora, you look awful!”

And she really did; sunken eyes, clammy, pale skin, her comforter wrapped around her shoulders making her look puny. She shuffled miserably into the kitchen, and all but threw herself into the breakfast nook. “My body is betraying me.”

Bow just hummed. “How so? Glim, can you start the smoothies?”

“Sure, babe.”

Adora just groaned into the bench cushions. “I feel gross. And… splorpy.”

Glimmer barked out a laugh. “Splorpy?”

“Yes, Glimmer, splorpy.”

“What does splorpy feel like?”

“Bad.” She huffed. Bow plated up the food while glimmer blended the smoothies. When they sat down, Adora was upright once again but just barely. “My chest hurts, my throat hurts, I can’t breathe through my nose. My body is aching like I went three rounds with Coach Huntara. My ears are like, ringing, and I keep coughing up mucus. Oh, and I’m warm. And freezing. Weezing.”

Bow nonchalantly pushed Adora’s plate further down the nook, away from his own. “Hm. Have you taken your temperature?”

“No.” Adora pouted.

Glimmer sighed, and got up to grab the thermometer from the bathroom. Adora stuck it under her tongue with much groaning, trying to shove a mouthful of omelet in alongside it. She ceased and desisted when she almost crunched the thermometer between her molars.

“Yep.” Glimmer pulled the stick out when it beeped. “102.7. Back to bed for you.”

“Coach is gonna kill me.” Adora sighed. Glimmer and Bow, despite the germs, moved to hug her on either side. They squeezed tighter when they heard her actually start sniffling.

“Hey, hey, it’s okay,” Glimmer soothed. “One day to rest and recover won’t kill you. You’ll be back on the mat by Tuesday, as long as you actually rest, Adora.”

“C’mon,” Bow picked up her plate and smoothie. “Let’s get you set up with some Animal Crossing and breakfast in bed. And water. And medicine. Oh and maybe a heating pad-”

“Babe, she’s got a cold, not the plague.” Glimmer rolled her eyes, but grabbed Adora’s hydroflask out of limp, clammy fingers to dump the old water and refill it with the fridge dispenser. She

snagged extra napkins and a plastic grocery bag out of the kitchen as she went, for any messes that may arise.

Adora's room, once militant and spartan, was finally starting to look homey and lived in. Glimmer had helped her paint it a warm, sunny yellow, and the three of them had made a sunset-themed accent wall on the side of the room her bed rested on. Her grey comforter had been swapped for a thick red duvet, and she even had throw blankets and some care-worn stuffed animals out on the bed. She was currently wrapped in a crocheted blanket from her great aunt Razz, having discarded the old comforter to the carpet, and holding her massive as fuck-all stuffed horse, Swiftwind. The thing was patchy and matted, no longer white but a beige-y grey, and had probably once looked identical to Adora's actual white gelding back home, sans the rainbow hair.

Glimmer lowered the overhead lights, smiling at the silly stick-on glow stars they'd helped her put up a year ago after Adora's first national victory. Bow had left her food on the nightstand, and was setting up her Switch on the TV. Glimmer scowled at the Animal Crossing load-up screen. "I don't understand what you see in these rude animals."

"They're my friends," Adora wheezed, and then coughed. "Besides, you play Minecraft and Call of Duty to unwind, so I don't wanna hear it, Commander Glimmer."

"Fair enough." Glimmer chuckled.

"I'll make some of that Italian wedding soup for lunch, 'kay?"

Adora smiled and tried to thank them, but sneezed hard enough to bang her head on the headboard, so she left it at a wave.

Glimmer sighed as they closed the door. "Time to disinfect everything?"

"I'll get the Clorox wipes." Bow pecked her on the forehead, and she swatted his butt as he walked by. "Don't forget we have to go get you more eyeshadow before we get ready for tonight."

Stars, she loved that man.

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"If you and Bow kiss goodnight one more time, I will not protect you from whatever hell Glimmer reigns down."

"But dearest, you have to kiss the homies goodnight! It's polite!"

Mermista heaved a long-suffering sigh as she unlocked her apartment's door. She kicked off her strappy gold heels, hung up her coat and keys on their respective hooks, and made her way to the kitchen. She heard the sounds of sneakers flying in different directions, a leather jacket being tossed over the back of her couch, and rolled her eyes. Typical.

"All I'm saying is, you could both stand to be a little less enthusiastic about it. Especially considering, y'know, the whole former butt-buddies thing."

"Oh, please, that's not even a factor," Sea Hawk accepted the glass of water from her, chugging it in three large gulps. Mermista sipped hers like a human being. "We're both happily…entangled."

She snorted into her glass, just barely avoiding spraying water. "Is that what you call it?"

"Well, last time I said dating, my lucky mask mysteriously disappeared right before my Regionals meet."

"Hmmm, how bizarre."

"Bizarre indeed." Sea Hawk leaned against the granite countertop of the island, looking unfairly attractive. Well, to drunk Mermista, he was always attractive. Sober Mermista would sooner die than admit he was anything past average. The silence stretched on, comfortable for her, but from the way Sea Hawk was twitching, drumming his fingers, casting his eyes around her kitchen, unbearable for him. "So, what's your schedule for tomorrow?"

“I’m in at eight, I’ve got laps until nine, yoga from nine-thirty to ten, then three hours diving. After that I’m at lunch, and then pilates, cardio, and weight circuits ‘til, like five. You?”

“Eight is stretching and cardio, at nine I’ve got agility and then I’m doing free weights. At eleven we pair off by blade for warm-ups and bouts, and then after a short lunch we’ll be on the strip until six.”

“Jeez, sounds rough. How long for lunch?”

“We have a conference on Friday,” Sea Hawk shrugged. “About an hour, at around one.”

“Cool,” Mermista picked at her nails, black glittering acrylics of a modest length. They’d be snapping in the weight room tomorrow anyway. “There’s a new food truck parked by the Common Area, if you don’t already have plans.”

Sea Hawk was suddenly crowding her, bracketing her in with an arm against the granite on either side of her body, grinning like a loon. “Why, dearest, are you asking me to lunch?”

“Oh darn I just remembered that Perfuma wanted to go to that vegan place on fifth-”

“No take-backsieeees,” he sang. “It’s a date. I’ll meet you by the horse statue.”

“If you must.” She rolled her eyes, but the effect was dampened by her hand coming to rest alongside his neck, scratching gently before trailing down his shirt. Sea Hawk leaned in to rub his bristly, stupid mustache against her neck, and she let him for a few seconds, enjoying the warmth of his body pressed against hers. Eventually, though, she grew impatient. “So…do you only kiss the homies goodnight or…?”

“Well, that depends,” his mouth trailed up to her ear and- hello, those were teeth. “Does a kiss goodnight mean I have to leave?”

“Hmmm,” Mermista pretended to think, even as she discarded her water glass in the sink to lead him out of the kitchen by the collar of his t-shirt. “I suppose that depends.”

Sea Hawk pressed his lips to hers as they crossed the threshold to the bedroom, and Mermista decided that, no, a kiss goodnight didn’t have to mean anything more than this.

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Perfuma was not having a very peaceful Monday morning. Her sunrise alarm clock hadn’t gotten enough solar charging that overcast weekend, so it died halfway through the night, leaving her to wake up naturally at seven-thirty for an eight-fifteen krav maga class. So, she had no time for a shower, or breakfast, or her green smoothie, or any sort of meditation whatsoever before she was sprinting out the door of her apartment, across the ‘Plex campus to her self-defense class. Luckily, her students were just as sleepy as she was, and no one had minded the extra five minutes to stretch on the mat.

She texted Mermista about her struggles, and despite the lack of sympathy from her so-called best friend, the diver had swung by the class.

“Here. I grabbed you a breakfast bowl from the caf, and I had extra protein shake this morning so you get that, too. I drank some of it, but I didn’t think you’d mind.”

“‘Mista, I owe you!” Perfuma threw her arms around Mermista’s neck and squeezed until she grunted, and patted her back in return. “You’re the best.”

“Yeah, yeah, don’t mention it.” She grumbled, shoving the food into Perfuma’s arms. She called for a ten minute break, and they sat on the mat while she dove into her breakfast. “Sooo why couldn’t your girlfriend come help you out with this?”

“She isn’t in until noon, and I felt bad waking her- she doesn’t get enough sleep, or at least, I don’t think she does. And you were

here so…”

“Whatever,” Mermista rolled her eyes, sipping her black coffee and scrolling through her phone. “Just drink the shake. I used, like, my really good powder in there and I don’t want it going to waste.”

“Why’d you make extra of your good stuff?” Perfuma frowned around some egg white and cheese.

“Ugh!” Mermista’s head thunked against the wall. “I made some for Sea Hawk, but he, like, ‘wasn’t hungry’ this morning or whatever. Asshole.”

Perfuma smiled to herself. “Well, his loss is my gain.” She took a sip of the shake, and then another larger one. “Wow, this is good.”

“Duh, I made it.” Mermista tossed her hair.

Conversation meandered as Perfuma ate; they talked about their next collabs on Tiktok, weekend plans for the spa, the upcoming Olympic pre-screening season, their partners (or, not-partners). When the ten minutes was up, Perfuma felt refreshed physically and emotionally. She gave Mermista a softer hug, and it was returned with minimal groaning.

“Have a good day?”

“Don’t tell me what to do.” Mermista flashed her a peace sign and sauntered out the door.

Perfuma turned back to her class. “Alright, let’s get into our basic forms!”

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Scorpia had had a great day! She had a short Monday training session, only in from noon to five, with a break for lunch around three. A lazy morning in, a good warm up, a great lunch with her

best friend Catra, all before getting in the ring and absolutely dominating for an hour and a half. And then her coach had told her that the Olympics, in an effort to demonstrate diversity and inclusivity, were honoring her bid for entry.

Perfuma had cried when she told her the good news, and from there the evening had only gotten better. Dinner at her favorite restaurant, her favorite movie, and now she was tangled up in bed with her most favorite person in the whole universe. This was, like, the best Monday in the whole world!

"Are you nervous?" Perfuma murmured against her collarbone, half-asleep.

Scorpia was always honest with Perfuma. Well, she tried to be always honest all the time, and not just because she was a bad liar. It was good for the soul.

When Scorpia had lost her forearms in a car accident at nine, she had been extremely certain her life was over. The first prosthetics hadn't come for three months after the accident, and her grandfather, as much as he loved her, had taken their arrival to mean she was magically independent again. She wasn't. In fact, she wouldn't be even remotely independent until she was twelve, and, in an act of desperation, had agreed to let the local University's robotics professor and her…husband? Sugar daddy? Lab partner?... experiment on her prosthetics.

Of course, Entrapta was a genius, and Hordak, as someone with physical disabilities of his own, had been able to offer unique perspective. They had given her back two state-of-the-art prosthetic arms with hands so responsive it was like a dream. But, that hadn't stopped the anger, or made the bullying go away. So, after a few years of constant fights, detentions, suspensions, and tanking grades, Entrapta had brought her along to the Megaplex under the guise of needing someone to hand her tools for the day while she fixed the scoreboards.

That day, Scorpia had found boxing. Coach Octavia had let her hang around the gym for the day, and when she came back the next week, tossed her a pair of custom gloves.

“If you’re going to take up space in my gym, you could at least make it worth both of our times’.”

And she’d never looked back. Scorpia had a future here, titles and medals and accolades to her name. She was going to the Olympics. She was going to be on international television, for all the world to see. For every other little kid who didn’t look like the others, who were disabled, who thought they’d never have a shot.

“Nah,” Scorpia smiled at her girlfriend, and kissed her softly. “I’m not nervous.”

“Good,” Perfuma kissed her again, and then again just for good measure. “I’m so proud of you.”

Scorpia giggled, deliriously happy. “I’m proud of me, too.”

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Spinnerella ran into her wife, quite literally, in the hallway on Wednesday, and did a double take at the unfiltered frustration sitting on her beautiful face. “Darling? What’s the matter?”

“Those fucking dumbass kids are what’s the matter!” Netossa threw up her hands, and shoved a phone into her wife’s hands. Spinerella traded her for the hefty clipboard in her arms, pulling over to the side of the hallway to read through the texts she had been sent.

Coach, I apologize for my continued absence, the doctor tells me I have mononucleosis. I don’t know how this happened. I will put in extra hours this weekend to compensate for my time lose. Once again, I’m sorry.

zdorovo coach. still feel like shit. doc gave me antibiotics, says its mono. should be back in by tomorrow. my b.

Hey Netossa! I went to the Doctor- they say its mono :((I should be through the worst of it though and back in by Friday.

NETOSSA! I AM SO SORRY! I don't know how this happened this is all my fault, I'm sure. Everyone else seems sick, too, this is such a disaster. I am so sorry. I will make this better. Somehow.
Also this is Bow, and I have mono.

Coach! I pray this message finds you in fine mettle, hale and whole. It seems I have contracted mononucosis. Monoleisos. Mononononoclose.
Mono.
I have been given medication, and should be right as rain by tomorrow. PLEASE DON'T REPLACE ME IN THE LINEUP. Have a fair day :)

Hey Coach. I'm lowkey fucked up from these meds and this whole..sick thing. Should be good by this weekend. Maybe. I'll keep u posted. Byeeee.

Hello Netossa, i'm afraid i've caught the bug everyone else has :(the doctor is sending some pills for me and Scorpia today, she's down for the count as well. I hope you're alright!

Hey Coach :(i've got mono and its real bad. I wouldnt miss practice otherwise, i swear it on my lucky gloves. I'm gonna work so hard to relax and let my body kick this virus, I'm sure i'll be good by sunday, and I'll put in extra hours all week to make up the lost time. Sorry!

Spinnerella really didn't mean to laugh. But how could she not? Netossa was slamming the hollow plastic clipboard into her forehead over and over, muttering obscenities into the paper attached. "It happens, darling-"

"To all of my star players?!" Netossa burst out. "At once?! And they're all idiots if they think they're going to be better before next Thursday at the earliest. Mono isn't just some cold!"

“Well, they do all hang out a lot together. They share housing, and food, and drinks. It was bound to catch like wildfire. And, anyway, they’re all very healthy. I’m sure it won’t be any longer than seven, maybe ten days.”

“How did this even happen?”

“My research had led me to believe that Double Trouble, a mutual acquaintance of many of the afflicted, is the so-called ground zero of this outbreak.”

Spinerella and Netossa turned as one to see Entrapta standing just behind them, tapping away at a large tablet strapped to her arm. “What?”

“Scorpia and Catra told me what happened, and correlating it with my own recent experience, it would make the most logical sense.”

“You have mono?” Netossa practically threw herself down the hallway, yanking her shirt up over her nose. Spinnerella rolled her eyes at her alleged ‘better half’ and took a conservative half-step back.

“No, had mono. Past tense. My antibodies worked optimally and my recent test came back totally clean.”

“So how did you…”

“Oh, well it’s quite simple!” Entrapta swiveled the iPad to show Spinnerella, and a hesitant Netossa, a flowchart. “Catra told me she and Adora shared a drink with ‘DT’ at their club on Friday. Adora lives with Glimmer and Bow. Bow and Sea Hawk ‘kissed the homies goodnight’ on Sunday. Sea Hawk presumably gave it to Mermista, who brought Perfuma breakfast to share on Monday. Perfuma gave it to Scorpia, and that’s how they all became infected in such a short period of time.”

“I’m going to kill them.” Netossa hit herself with the clipboard once more before Spinnerella snatched it away.

"If their cases were like mine and Hordak's, and they must be, with the same source, they should all be fine by Sunday the latest."

"Wait," Spinnerella frowned. "How did you get it?"

"Hordak!"

"Riiiiight," she nodded. "But…how did he get it? From the same source?"

"Oh, we went to help Double Trouble set up their new under-floor lighting displays, and they got to drinking together, and at some point or another, wound up, what's the colloquial…'making out'?"

Netossa spluttered. "You let your husband make out with- with- girl why?"

Entrapta frowned, tilting her head, before realization dawned. "Ohhhh. You are under the presumption that because we're legally married, Hordak and I are monogamous."

"Uh…yes. Yes we were."

"Oh! Well, we aren't. We got married for better tax breaks."

"So you aren't…you don't love…him?"

"Sure I do," Entrapta shrugged. "In my experience, the definition of 'love' is…myriad. And complex. I'm sure that while we all feel love for our partners, we don't all feel the exact same release pattern of chemicals in the brain in the exact same way."

Spinnerella smiled. "What works for some people doesn't work for others. And vice versa."

"Yes, precisely," Entrapta smiled guilessly. "Now, if you'll excuse me, I need to go repair the fencing team's electrical hookups. Have a good day!"

The tiny scientist disappeared around the corner, tapping away on her iPad. Netossa heaved a long, labored sigh, and gave her wife an assessing look. “Wanna go get lunch? Preferably somewhere with a bar?”

“Darling, it’s eleven in the morning.”

“I don’t hear a no…”

Spinnerella checked her clipboard. No patients until two-thirty. “...Fine. But we aren’t sharing.”

“Amen.”

End Notes

Hope you enjoyed!! Getting comments on my fics makes my WHOLE DAY like I can't even explain it so if you enjoyed, drop by and say hi! And if you didn't you could also tell me that too I suppose lol

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!